

people who know this isn't true have largely internalized the message. Hell, this is what I thought about myself until recently. I'm a confident person, successful in my career, happy in my love life, surrounded by friends, close to my sister, and I still believed that because I didn't have a handle on my money situation, I must be a bad human and a worthless failure. How could I know any differently? My friends who had jobs didn't discuss their salaries, and my friends without jobs never explained where their money came from or revealed that they were struggling. I figured everyone around me knew something I didn't.

It came to a head for me after college. I spent my early 20s working as a freelance writer/reporter, with the occasional 9-to-5 reporting gig at various publications. When I was freelancing, I always felt deeply mortified to press the magazines or blogs I was writing for to give me my owed paychecks—which were *always* late (#freelancelife). If you've ever been a freelancer, you are aware of the cruel truth that a place that owes you money is never in ANY hurry to send you your check. Big payment, small payment: It doesn't matter. Trying to get paid becomes its own full-time job. I worried that if I needed money (as a 20-something living in New York City, no duh, of course I did), I would look desperate. The optics of seeming like a "carefree New York hipster debutante" to some strangers in *Cosmo* magazine's accounts payable department was more important to me than actually having money in my checking account.

Sometimes I had to literally beg in multiple emails for freelance jobs to pay me specifically because rent was due and I had nothing. (And I would tell them that! Horrifying!) Once it took a whole year for a major international publication to cut me a \$500 check. And instead of being angry at them, I was MORTIFIED that I needed that money so badly. It made me feel pathetic and unimportant. They should have been embarrassed by their shitty treatment of a freelancer, but they weren't. I was.

Don't get me wrong: I was delighted by the bylines I got in *Playboy* and the *New York Times Magazine*. I posted about them on Facebook and received all the comments and likes and validation I could have ever wanted. People thought I was thriving. They thought I was successful. Maybe they thought I was making good money.